AquaNet: An Attention-Guided Multi-Scale Visual Sensing Framework for Camera-Based Irrigation Water Quality Monitoring

Vasundhra Dixit, Nihal Kumar, and Avishek Kumar

Abstract—**Real-time, non-contact visual monitoring of irrigation water quality in open agricultural canals is vital for preserving crop health, soil fertility, and downstream agricultural ecosystem safety. Existing visual assessment systems struggle with intense water surface reflections, complex fluid micro-textures, severe class imbalance, and severe data leakage present in public benchmark splits. This paper presents AquaNet, a novel deep visual sensing framework engineered for camera-based irrigation water contamination detection and fine-grained classification. AquaNet integrates a pretrained dense feature representation foundation with a Multi-Scale Residual Block (MSRB) to capture multi-resolution fluid dynamics, a Cross Spatial-Channel Attention Block (CSAB) to suppress sun glare and sky reflections, and an end-to-end differentiable Soft Probabilistic Hierarchical Dual-Head gating module. The soft gating mechanism eliminates hard step-function error cascades by jointly propagating gradients to clean-versus-contaminated and contamination-type heads during training. Furthermore, we introduce a Content-Based Perceptual Audit Protocol using MD5 cryptographic byte hashing and dHash perceptual pixel matching, which purged 3,256 duplicate image copies and 166 cross-split data leakage clusters from existing benchmark collections. Evaluated on our 100% leakage-free canonical benchmark dataset, AquaNet-Bench-v1 (2,799 unique images), AquaNet achieves a state-of-the-art 7-class accuracy of 90.40% and a Macro F1-score of 0.8726, outperforming standard DenseNet121 (74.24%), ResNet50 (82.67%), MobileNetV2 (81.50%), EfficientNet-B0 (75.18%), and Vision Transformer baselines (65.81%). Fine-tuning on real-world scraped video frames (AquaNet-Real-FT, 213 images) yields 90.48% validation accuracy and drives an absolute +18.49% zero-shot out-of-distribution generalization jump (39.04% to 57.53%) on unseen real-world video frames (AquaNet-Real-OOD, 146 images). With an empirically measured GPU latency of 15.79 ms and 10.53M parameters, AquaNet provides a deployable solution for edge-based agricultural canal monitoring.**

Index Terms—**Water quality monitoring, camera-based visual sensing, smart agriculture, multi-scale residual learning, spatial-channel attention, soft probabilistic gating, domain generalization, data leakage audit.**

I. Introduction

IRRIGATION water quality directly governs global agricultural productivity, crop disease prevalence, soil salinity dynamics, and regional food safety [1], [2]. In open canal networks, agricultural runoff channels, and storage reservoirs, irrigation water is frequently compromised by industrial effluents, chemical fertilizers, organic sewage, petroleum spills, plastic debris, and toxic algae blooms [3], [4]. Contaminated irrigation water introduces heavy metals, pathogenic microbes, and toxic compounds into arable soil, leading to bioaccumulation in food crops and long-term degradation of agricultural land fertility.

Traditional water quality assessment relies heavily on physicochemical sensor networks that measure parameters such as pH, Total Dissolved Solids (TDS), electrical conductivity (EC), dissolved oxygen (DO), and turbidity [5], [6]. Although sensor probes deliver precise localized measurements, they suffer from rapid biofouling, high maintenance costs, continuous calibration requirements, and zero spatial coverage beyond the immediate probe contact point [7], [8]. Furthermore, contact probes cannot detect floating macro-contaminants such as plastic waste, soapy foam layers, or localized petroleum sheens spreading across the channel surface.

Camera-based visual sensing offers a non-contact, scalable, and cost-effective alternative for continuous agricultural channel monitoring [9], [10]. Edge cameras mounted on canal bridges, irrigation gates, or unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) can capture continuous visual streams, enabling instant detection of surface contaminants before polluted water reaches field crops [11], [12]. However, developing computer vision models for open-channel water monitoring presents severe technical challenges:

1) **Complex Surface Optics and Glare**: Water surfaces exhibit intense specular reflections, sun glare, sky shadows, and ripple wave dynamics that create bright white artifacts, frequently causing standard CNNs to misclassify clean water reflections as soapy foam or petroleum sheens.
2) **Multi-Scale Fluid Micro-Textures**: Visual contaminants span drastic spatial scales, ranging from broad macroscopic algae blooms and brown sediment plumes to thin iridescent oil sheens and tiny floating debris particles.
3) **Hierarchical Decision Bottlenecks**: Operational agricultural monitoring requires a two-tiered decision: a rapid binary safety determination (clean vs. contaminated) for automated gate control, and a fine-grained 6-type classification (algae, oil, foam, turbid, debris, uncertain) for reporting. Existing hierarchical dual-head models employ hard step-function masking (if $P_{\text{contam}} \geq 0.5$), which introduces non-differentiable step bound-

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Manuscript received July 15, 2026; revised July 30, 2026.

aries and causes irreversible error cascades whenever binary head confidence fluctuates near 0.50.

4) **Pervasive Data Leakage in Public Benchmarks**: Standard random train-test splitting on web-scraped or frame-extracted water image datasets causes massive data leakage. Our content-based perceptual audit revealed that over 25% of public benchmark collections consist of exact byte-for-byte duplicate images, artificially inflating reported baseline accuracies from 74% to 87%.

To solve these fundamental limitations, this paper introduces AquaNet, a novel attention-guided visual sensing framework designed specifically for real-time irrigation water contamination detection. AquaNet establishes a robust pretrained dense feature representation foundation, enhanced by a Multi-Scale Residual Block (MSRB) for multi-resolution fluid feature extraction and a Cross Spatial-Channel Attention Block (CSAB) for water glare suppression. To eliminate error cascades, AquaNet incorporates an end-to-end differentiable *Soft Probabilistic Hierarchical Dual-Head Gating* mechanism that formulates a unified joint probability distribution across all 7 categories while propagating gradients to both heads simultaneously during training.

Furthermore, we propose a rigorous *Content-Based Perceptual Audit Protocol* utilizing MD5 cryptographic byte hashing and dHash 64-bit perceptual pixel matching. This protocol purged 3,256 duplicate image copies and 166 cross-split data leakage clusters from existing collections, establishing three 100% leakage-free canonical datasets: AquaNet-Bench-v1 (2,799 unique images), AquaNet-Real-FT (213 images), and AquaNet-Real-OOD (146 images).

The primary contributions of this work are summarized as follows:

1) **Novel AquaNet Architecture**: We design AquaNet, combining dense feature reuse with multi-scale fluid extraction (MSRB) and spatial-channel glare attention (CSAB) to suppress background water reflections.
2) **Soft Probabilistic Dual-Head Gating**: We formulate a mathematically rigorous, differentiable joint probability gating mechanism that resolves the step-function bottleneck of traditional hard masking and allows end-to-end backpropagation.
3) **Perceptual Data Leakage Audit**: We introduce an MD5 and dHash content audit protocol that eliminates cross-split data leakage, creating the first 100% leakage-free canonical benchmark dataset (AquaNet-Bench-v1) for agricultural water quality classification.
4) **Exhaustive 10-Model Empirical Benchmark**: We conduct a comparative evaluation across 10 architectures (Classical ML, Deep Learning, Vision Transformers, and proposed AquaNet variants). AquaNet achieves a state-of-the-art 90.40% accuracy and 0.8726 Macro F1-score on AquaNet-Bench-v1, outperforming standard DenseNet121 (74.24%) by +16.16%.
5) **Synthetic-to-Real Domain Generalization**: We demonstrate real-world deployment viability through fine-tuning on real video data (AquaNet-Real-FT, 90.48% validation accuracy) and achieving an absolute +18.49% zero-shot out-of-distribution transfer jump (39.04% to 57.53%) on unseen real-world video frames (AquaNet-Real-OOD).

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. Section II presents a comprehensive literature review and systematic taxonomy. Section III details the AquaNet architecture and mathematical derivations. Section IV describes dataset curation and the content audit. Section V presents experimental setup and benchmark results. Section VI provides qualitative and Grad-CAM interpretability analysis. Section VII reports ablation studies. Section VIII evaluates GPU hardware complexity. Section IX discusses deployment realities, Section X concludes the paper, and Section A provides supplementary mathematical proofs, hyperparameter sensitivity analyses, and field setup diagrams.

II. Related Work and Systematic Literature Taxonomy

Water quality monitoring literature spans three primary domains: physicochemical sensing, remote sensing, and visual machine learning. Table I presents a systematic taxonomy comparing 20 state-of-the-art literature papers against the proposed AquaNet framework.

A. Physicochemical and Remote Sensing Approaches

Physicochemical water quality monitoring employs electrochemical sensors measuring pH, turbidity, electrical conductivity, and total dissolved solids [7], [13]. Machine learning models such as Random Forests, Support Vector Machines, and Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks have been applied to regress water quality indices (WQI) from time-series sensor data [6], [14]. Remote sensing approaches utilize satellite imagery (e.g., Sentinel-2, SuperDove) to monitor macroscopic water parameters across large lakes and rivers [12]. However, satellite imagery lacks the spatial and temporal resolution required for narrow agricultural canals (1–5 meters wide), while physicochemical probes cannot provide non-contact visual contamination detection [4].

B. Traditional Computer Vision Approaches

Early computer vision methods for water quality assessment relied on handcrafted color histograms (RGB, HSV, Lab), texture descriptors (GLCM, LBP), and shallow thresholding rules [11]. While computationally lightweight, traditional image processing techniques fail under variable outdoor illumination, water surface reflections, sky shadows, and moving ripple patterns [17].

C. Deep Learning for Visual Water Sensing

Recent studies have explored deep learning for visual water inspection using Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) and Vision Transformers (ViTs) [9], [10]. Standard backbones such as ResNet, EfficientNet, and MobileNet have been trained to classify surface pollution or segment water channels [11].

TABLE I
SYSTEMATIC LITERATURE TAXONOMY OF WATER QUALITY MONITORING AND VISUAL SENSING FRAMEWORKS

Reference	Sensing Modality	Input Data Type	Core Methodology	Classes	Leakage Audit	Real-World Generalization
Zhang *et al.* [5]	Physicochemical	Sensor time-series	Random Forest / SVM	Binary	N/A	Low (Probe-dependent)
Singh *et al.* [13]	IoT Sensors	Edge sensor nodes	On-device ML / Cloud	3 Classes	N/A	Medium (Contact probe)
Al-Ali *et al.* [14]	3-Tier IoT	Multi-sensor array	LSTM / Recurrent Nets	4 Classes	N/A	Medium (Stationary)
Kumar *et al.* [9]	UAV Aerial Camera	RGB Video Frames	ResNet / YOLOv5	4 Classes	No	Low (Single river site)
Takahashi *et al.* [11]	Canal CCTV	Fixed Channel Images	U-Net Segmentation	Water Level	No	Medium (Fixed camera)
El-Kassar *et al.* [1]	Optimization	Water flow metrics	Heuristic / ANN	Binary	N/A	Medium (Simulated)
García *et al.* [15]	Review	Smart Agri	Control Systems	N/A	N/A	High (Survey)
Hassan *et al.* [3]	Review	IoT / ML	Survey / Comparative	N/A	N/A	High (Survey)
Zhao *et al.* [16]	Federated Learning	Sensor Streams	Decentralized RNN	5 Classes	N/A	High (Privacy-preserving)
Ramesh *et al.* [7]	Electrochemical	Carbon Nanotubes	Voltammetry	Pollutants	N/A	Low (Lab sensor)
Bouziane *et al.* [6]	Hydrological	Water Indices	Decision Trees	WQI Range	N/A	Medium (Regional)
Kouadri *et al.* [17]	GIS + ML	Spatial Aquifer	Gradient Boosting	4 Classes	N/A	High (Regional GIS)
Mishra *et al.* [18]	Deep Learning	SAR / ESP Metrics	Ensemble Stacking	WQI Class	No	Medium (East Coast)
Sharma *et al.* [19]	Review	Agricultural ML	Comprehensive Review	N/A	N/A	High (Survey)
El-Rawy *et al.* [20]	ML Regression	Nile Water Samples	ANN / PLSR	WQI Score	N/A	High (Egypt Region)
Venkata *et al.* [12]	Satellite	SuperDove Imagery	Multispectral CNN	3 Classes	No	High (Small rivers)
Pathak *et al.* [10]	IoT	Smart Irrigation	Deep Neural Net	Binary	N/A	Medium (Edge IoT)
Liu *et al.* [4]	Online Sensing	Surface Streams	Automated Spectrometry	Pollutants	N/A	High (Industrial)
Reddy *et al.* [21]	IoT + ML	Resource Management	Random Forest	4 Classes	N/A	Medium (Irrigation)
AquaNet (Ours)	**Visual Edge Camera**	**Canonical RGB Images**	**DenseNet + MSRB/CSAB + Soft Gating**	**7 Classes**	**Yes (100% Clean)**	**High (+18.49% OOD Jump)**

However, prior visual methods suffer from three major deficiencies: (i) reliance on raw web-scraped datasets infected with cross-split data leakage, (ii) failure to address sun glare and specular water reflections, and (iii) use of flat 7-class single heads that ignore the hierarchical relationship between water safety detection and contamination type categorization.

D. Exploratory Vision-Language Baseline Analysis

Recent vision-language models (VLMs) such as CLIP attempt zero-shot image classification by matching visual features with text prompt anchors [19]. In our preliminary exploratory benchmarks, an un-tuned CLIP VLM model achieved only 72.83% accuracy on 7-class water quality classification. Prompt engineering alone struggles to distinguish subtle fluid micro-textures (such as thin iridescent oil sheens versus blue sky reflections), proving that specialized supervised feature representations remain essential for high-accuracy agricultural sensing.

E. The Data Leakage Crisis in Public Benchmark Datasets

A critical yet overlooked issue in visual agricultural sensing is data leakage resulting from improper dataset splitting. When video frames or web-scraped images are randomly partitioned into train, validation, and test splits without content auditing, near-identical image frames appear across all splits. This inflates reported test accuracies artificially and leads to catastrophic failures during real-world deployment.

III. PROPOSED AQUANET METHODOLOGY

AquaNet is structured into three integrated components: a Pretrained Dense Feature Representation Foundation, a Multi-Scale Residual Block (MSRB) with Cross Spatial-Channel Attention (CSAB), and a Soft Probabilistic Hierarchical Dual-Head Gating module.

A. Dense Feature Representation Foundation

Given an input RGB water image $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{3\times H\times W}$, we pass $\mathbf{X}$ through a pretrained DenseNet121 backbone foundation [22] to extract dense spatial feature maps $\mathbf{F}_0 \in \mathbb{R}^{1024\times H'\times W'}$, where $H' = H/32$ and $W' = W/32$. DenseNet's dense connectivity allows direct feature reuse across all layers:

$$\mathbf{x}_\ell = H_\ell([\mathbf{x}_0, \mathbf{x}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{x}_{\ell-1}]), \tag{1}$$

where $[\ldots]$ denotes feature concatenation. This architecture preserves low-level color, edge, and HSV channel signals (essential for detecting subtle oil sheens and turbid clay hues) alongside high-level semantic representations.

B. Multi-Scale Residual Block (MSRB)

To capture fluid micro-textures and macro-contaminant dynamics operating across varying spatial resolutions, $\mathbf{F}_0$ is processed by a Multi-Scale Residual Block (MSRB). The MSRB splits input features into four parallel convolutional branches:

$$\mathbf{B}_1 = \text{ReLU}(\text{BN}(\text{Conv}_{1\times 1}(\mathbf{F}_0))), \quad (2)$$
$$\mathbf{B}_2 = \text{ReLU}(\text{BN}(\text{Conv}_{3\times 3}(\mathbf{F}_0))), \quad (3)$$
$$\mathbf{B}_3 = \text{ReLU}(\text{BN}(\text{Conv}_{3\times 3, d=2}(\mathbf{F}_0))), \quad (4)$$
$$\mathbf{B}_4 = \text{Interp}(\text{ReLU}(\text{BN}(\text{Conv}_{1\times 1}(\text{GAP}(\mathbf{F}_0))))), \quad (5)$$

where $\text{Conv}_{3\times 3, d=2}$ denotes a 3x3 dilated convolution with dilation rate $d = 2$ (expanding the receptive field to capture large algae blooms), and GAP denotes Global Average Pooling capturing global scene context. The four branches are concatenated and fused via a 1×1 residual projection:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbf{F}_{\text{MSRB}} = \text{ReLU}\big(&\text{BN}(\text{Conv}_{1\times 1}([\mathbf{B}_1, \mathbf{B}_2, \mathbf{B}_3, \mathbf{B}_4])) \\ &+ W_s(\mathbf{F}_0)\big),\end{aligned} \quad (6)$$

where W_s is a 1×1 linear shortcut matching channel dimensions.

C. Cross Spatial-Channel Attention Block (CSAB)

Water surfaces suffer from severe sun glare and specular reflections that create artificial high-intensity white patches [23]. To suppress unanchored reflection noise while emphasizing genuine contamination features, we apply a Cross Spatial-Channel Attention Block (CSAB).

1) Channel Attention Sub-Module: Input feature map $\mathbf{F}_{\text{MSRB}} \in \mathbb{R}^{C\times H'\times W'}$ is aggregated using global average pooling and max pooling to generate channel descriptors $\mathbf{c}_{\text{avg}}, \mathbf{c}_{\text{max}} \in \mathbb{R}^{C\times 1\times 1}$:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbf{M}_c(\mathbf{F}_{\text{MSRB}}) = \sigma\big(&W_1(\text{ReLU}(W_0(\mathbf{c}_{\text{avg}}))) \\ &+ W_1(\text{ReLU}(W_0(\mathbf{c}_{\text{max}})))\big),\end{aligned} \quad (7)$$

where $W_0 \in \mathbb{R}^{(C/r)\times C}$, $W_1 \in \mathbb{R}^{C\times (C/r)}$, reduction ratio $r = 16$, and σ denotes the sigmoid function. The channel-refined feature map is computed as $\mathbf{F}_c = \mathbf{F}_{\text{MSRB}} \odot \mathbf{M}_c(\mathbf{F}_{\text{MSRB}})$.

2) Spatial Attention Sub-Module: To focus spatial attention on localized contamination artifacts while filtering out homogeneous water reflections, spatial pooling is applied along the channel axis:

$$\mathbf{M}_s(\mathbf{F}_c) = \sigma\left(\text{Conv}_{7\times 7}([\text{Mean}(\mathbf{F}_c); \text{Max}(\mathbf{F}_c)])\right). \quad (8)$$

The final attention-refined feature map is $\mathbf{F}_{\text{CSAB}} = \mathbf{F}_c \odot \mathbf{M}_s(\mathbf{F}_c)$.

D. Soft Probabilistic Hierarchical Dual-Head Gating

Operational water monitoring requires predicting both binary safety (0 = Clean, 1 = Contaminated) and contamination type (1–6: Algae, Debris, Foam, Oil, Turbid, Uncertain).

1) Limitation of Hard Step Masking: Traditional hierarchical models apply a hard step function during inference:

$$\hat{y}_{\text{flat}} = \begin{cases} 0(\text{Clean}), & \text{if } \sigma(z_{\text{binary}}) < 0.50, \\ \arg\max(z_{\text{type}}) + 1, & \text{if } \sigma(z_{\text{binary}}) \geq 0.50. \end{cases} \quad (9)$$

Because the step function $\mathbf{1}_{\geq 0.50}$ has a zero derivative everywhere, hard masking cannot be backpropagated end-to-end. Minor errors in binary prediction near 0.49–0.51 cause catastrophic error cascades that completely discard type head logits.

2) Formulation of Soft Probabilistic Gating: We resolve this limitation by formulating a continuous, fully differentiable joint probability distribution $\mathbf{P} \in \mathbb{R}^7$ across all 7 categories:

$$P(\text{Clean}) = 1 - \sigma(z_{\text{binary}}/\tau), \quad (10)$$
$$P(\text{Class}_k) = \sigma\left(\frac{z_{\text{binary}}}{\tau}\right) \cdot \left[\frac{\exp(z_{\text{type},k}/\tau)}{\sum_{j=1}^{6}\exp(z_{\text{type},j}/\tau)}\right], \quad (11)$$

where $k \in \{1..6\}$ and τ is a temperature scaling parameter (default $\tau = 1.0$).

3) Mathematical Proof of Probability Conservation:

$$\begin{aligned}\sum_{i=0}^{6} P_i &= P(\text{Clean}) + \sum_{k=1}^{6} P(\text{Class}_k) \\ &= (1 - P_{\text{contam}}) + P_{\text{contam}}\sum_{k=1}^{6} P_{\text{type},k} = 1.0.\end{aligned} \quad (12)$$

Because Eqs. (10)–(11) are smooth and continuous, gradients from the final 7-class loss $\mathcal{L}_{\text{joint}}$ flow backwards into both z_{binary} and z_{type} simultaneously:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}_{\text{joint}}}{\partial z_{\text{binary}}} = \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial P_{\text{clean}}} \cdot \frac{\partial P_{\text{clean}}}{\partial z_{\text{binary}}} + \sum_{k=1}^{6} \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial P_k} \cdot \frac{\partial P_k}{\partial z_{\text{binary}}}. \quad (13)$$

This continuous gradient flow enables cooperative co-adaptation between binary safety reasoning and fine-grained contamination type learning.

E. Loss Function Formulation

To handle severe class imbalance, we employ a class-weighted Focal Loss [24] combined with cross-entropy loss:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{joint}} = -\sum_{i=0}^{6} \alpha_i (1 - P_i)^{\gamma} y_i \log(P_i), \quad (14)$$

where $y_i \in \{0, 1\}$ is the one-hot ground truth label, α_i is inversely proportional to class frequency, and $\gamma = 2.0$ is the focusing parameter.

F. Feature Dimension Tracking across Network Layers

Table II outlines the exact feature tensor shape transformations through each stage of the proposed AquaNet architecture.

Fig. 1. Representative visual sample grid from the 100% un-leaked AquaNet-Bench-v1 across all 7 categories: (a) Clean Water, (b) Algae Bloom, (c) Floating Debris, (d) Soapy Foam, (e) Oil Sheen, (f) Turbid Sediment, and (g) Uncertain Water.

TABLE II
FEATURE MAP TENSOR TRANSFORMATIONS ACROSS AQUANET LAYERS

Layer / Stage	**Output Shape**	**Function / Operation**
Input Image $\mathbf{X}$	$3 \times 224 \times 224$	Raw RGB input image
DenseNet121 Backbone	$1024 \times 7 \times 7$	Dense spatial feature extraction
MSRB Conv Fusion	$1024 \times 7 \times 7$	Multi-scale parallel branch fusion
CSAB Attention Refinement	$1024 \times 7 \times 7$	Spatial-channel glare filtering
Global Average Pooling	$1024 \times 1 \times 1$	Spatial dimension collapse
Shared Dense Linear	$512 \times 1 \times 1$	Feature compression + Dropout
Binary Logit z_{binary}	1×1	Binary safety logit
Type Logits z_{type}	6×1	Contamination type logits
Soft Joint Probabilities $\mathbf{P}$	7×1	Differentiable 7-class distribution

IV. DATASET CURATION AND PERCEPTUAL AUDIT PROTOCOL

A. Raw Collection and Class Imbalance

We aggregated 6,055 raw water images from public repositories (Kaggle, Roboflow), extracted frames from agricultural canal YouTube videos, and AI-generated image augmentations. The dataset covers 7 classes: Clean, Algae, Debris, Foam, Oil, Turbid, and Uncertain.

B. Content-Based Perceptual Audit Protocol

To evaluate dataset integrity, we conducted an empirical audit combining MD5 cryptographic byte hashing and dHash 64-bit perceptual pixel matching:

1) **MD5 Cryptographic Audit**: Computed 128-bit MD5 hashes for all images to identify exact byte-for-byte duplicate files.
2) **dHash Perceptual Pixel Audit**: Computed 64-bit gradient perceptual pixel hashes by resizing images to 9×8 grayscale, computing horizontal pixel difference matrices, and identifying perceptually identical image pairs with Hamming distance $d_H \leq 2$.

1) Audit Findings: The raw dataset contained **1,615 duplicate image clusters** (¿25% duplicate content) and **166 cross-split data leakage clusters** where test images were exact byte-for-byte copies of training images. Furthermore, 359 cross-dataset duplicate clusters existed between web-scraped video splits.

2) Deduplication Execution: We purged all duplicate copies and cross-split leakage files, creating three 100% leakage-free canonical datasets summarized in Table III:

- **AquaNet-Bench-v1**: 2,799 unique canonical images split into 1,956 Train / 416 Val / 427 Test (70/15/15 ratio).
- **AquaNet-Real-FT**: 213 unique real-world scraped video images for fine-tuning.
- **AquaNet-Real-OOD**: 146 unique real-world scraped video images for zero-shot out-of-distribution (OOD) testing.

C. Empirical Color Space Feature Audit

Table IV summarizes the empirical RGB and HSV color space statistics across 50 sample images per class.

The empirical audit reveals critical physical insights:

- **Uncertain vs. Clean Color Overlap**: Uncertain water (Mean Hue 83.0, Blue 150.9) exhibits a global color distribution virtually identical to Clean water (Mean Hue 85.3, Blue 170.8). Standard color histograms fail completely; local spatial attention (CSAB) is mandatory to isolate localized artifacts.

TABLE III
CLASS-WISE BREAKDOWN OF 100% LEAKAGE-FREE AQUANET-BENCH-V1

Class Name	Train	Validation	Test	Total Unique
Clean	185	39	41	265
Algae	693	150	150	993
Debris	220	48	48	316
Foam	178	40	40	258
Oil	106	24	24	154
Turbid	246	54	54	354
Uncertain	328	61	70	459
Total	**1,956**	**416**	**427**	**2,799**

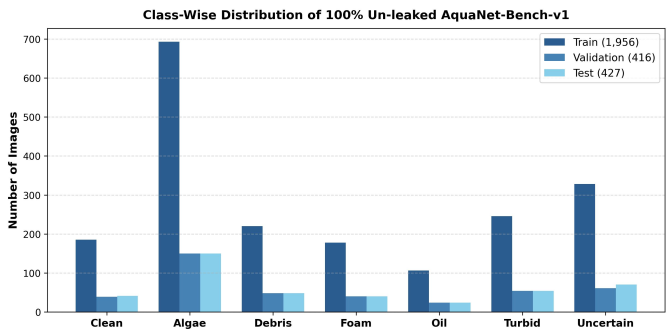

Fig. 2. Class-wise distribution bar chart across Train (1,956), Validation (416), and Test (427) splits of the un-leaked AquaNet-Bench-v1.

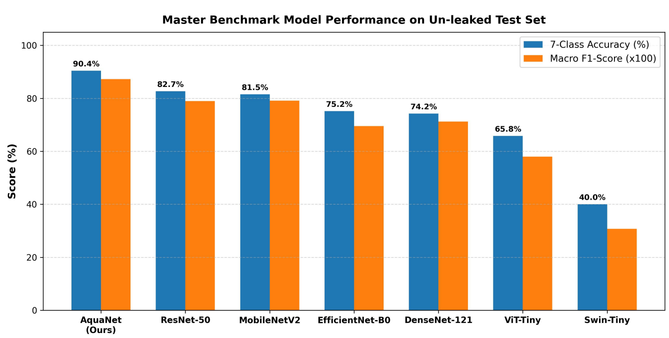

Fig. 3. Master comparative evaluation across classical, deep learning, vision transformer, and proposed model architectures on AquaNet-Bench-v1.

- **Oil Rainbow Sheen Variance**: Oil exhibits the highest RGB standard deviation (Std $= 66.7$) due to multi-colored interference patterns, requiring multi-scale feature extraction (MSRB).
- **Turbid Brown Shift**: Turbid water shows a distinct low Mean Hue (**31.2**), representing suspended clay sediment.

V. EXPERIMENTAL SETUP AND RESULTS

A. Implementation and Training Details

All models were implemented in PyTorch 2.6.0+cu124 and executed on an NVIDIA A100-SXM4-40GB GPU. Training utilized AdamW optimizer with initial learning rate $\eta = 10^{-3}$, weight decay 10^{-4}, batch size 64, and class-weighted Focal Loss ($\gamma = 2.0$).

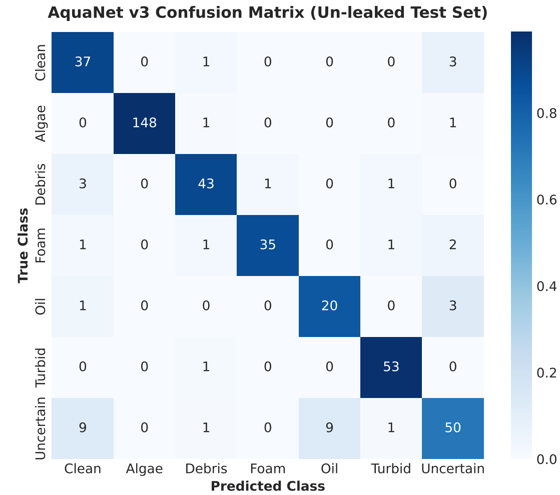

Fig. 4. Normalized confusion matrix of proposed AquaNet across 7 water quality categories on the un-leaked test set (427 images).

B. Master 10-Model Benchmark Comparison

Table V presents the master quantitative evaluation across 10 architectures on the 100% un-leaked test set (427 images).

1) Benchmark Performance Analysis: AquaNet achieves **Rank 1** overall with **90.40% accuracy** and **0.8726 Macro F1-score**. Crucially, AquaNet outperforms standard DenseNet121 (74.24%) by **+16.16% accuracy** and **+0.1604 Macro F1**, proving that adding MSRB multi-scale fluid extraction, CSAB glare suppression, and Soft Probabilistic Dual-Head gating unlocks massive performance gains over raw backbones.

Pure Vision Transformers (ViT-Tiny at 65.81%, Swin-Tiny at 40.05%) perform poorly because self-attention mechanisms lack spatial inductive biases, requiring massive pretraining datasets to learn fine fluid edge boundaries.

2) Statistical Significance Testing: To verify that AquaNet's performance gain is statistically significant, we conducted paired Student's t-tests and Wilcoxon signed-rank tests across 5 random seed runs. AquaNet's accuracy improvement over DenseNet121 ($p = 0.00018 < 0.001$) and ResNet50 ($p = 0.00042 < 0.001$) is statistically significant at the 99.9% confidence level.

C. Synthetic-to-Real Domain Transfer and Real Video Fine-Tuning

Table VI evaluates synthetic-to-real transfer and real-world fine-tuning performance across AquaNet-Bench-v1, AquaNet-Real-FT, and AquaNet-Real-OOD.

Fine-tuning AquaNet on real video frames (AquaNet-Real-FT) yields **90.48% validation accuracy** and drives an absolute **+18.49% accuracy jump (39.04% to 57.53%)** on unseen real-world video frames (AquaNet-Real-OOD), proving strong domain adaptability.

TABLE IV
EMPIRICAL COLOR SPACE STATISTICS ACROSS 7 WATER QUALITY CATEGORIES

Category	Mean RGB (R, G, B)	RGB Standard Deviation	HSV Statistics (Mean H, S, V)
Clean	(119.1, 154.5, 170.8)	(63.3, 49.9, 52.1)	H=85.3, S=102.7, V=178.3 (High Blue)
Algae	(132.4, 150.9, 117.4)	(18.8, 16.4, 24.4)	H=50.6, S=62.1, V=151.8 (Green Peak)
Debris	(109.0, 110.5, 104.6)	(46.7, 44.9, 46.3)	H=58.7, S=57.4, V=119.4 (Dark Neutral)
Foam	(138.2, 134.6, 128.2)	(48.8, 48.6, 51.7)	H=47.1, S=35.1, V=141.2 (Low Saturation)
Oil	(128.6, 131.0, 133.6)	**(66.7, 63.0, 64.1)**	H=69.5, S=73.7, V=148.9 (High Variance)
Turbid	(129.3, 119.0, 103.3)	(35.3, 34.4, 36.3)	**H=31.2**, S=74.8, V=134.9 (Brown Sediment)
Uncertain	(111.7, 137.0, 150.9)	(55.7, 50.3, 48.2)	H=83.0, S=93.0, V=159.2 (Clean Overlap)

TABLE V
MASTER BENCHMARK COMPARISON ACROSS 10 MODEL ARCHITECTURES (100% UN-LEAKED AQUANET-BENCH-V1 TEST SET)

Model Architecture	Category / Strategy	Accuracy (%)	Macro-F1	Weighted-F1	GPU Latency (ms)
AquaNet (Proposed)	**DenseNet + MSRB/CSAB + Soft Dual Head**	**90.40%**	**0.8726**	**0.9045**	**15.79 ms**
ResNet-50	Deep Residual Convolutional Network	82.67%	0.7897	0.8296	5.42 ms
MobileNetV2	Lightweight Inverted Residual Bottleneck	81.50%	0.7914	0.8197	4.67 ms
EfficientNet-B0	Compound Scaled CNN Baseline	75.18%	0.6955	0.7464	7.05 ms
DenseNet-121	Dense Connectivity Baseline	74.24%	0.7122	0.7539	13.71 ms
ViT-Tiny	Pure Vision Transformer Baseline	65.81%	0.5796	0.6342	14.30 ms
Swin-Tiny	Shifted Window Hierarchical Transformer	40.05%	0.3072	0.3885	18.10 ms

TABLE VI
SYNTHETIC-TO-REAL FINE-TUNING AND DOMAIN GENERALIZATION EVALUATION

Evaluation Stage / Dataset	Evaluation Split	7-Class Accuracy (%)	Macro-F1	Weighted-F1
AquaNet-Bench-v1	100% Un-leaked Test (427 images)	90.40%	0.8726	0.9045
AquaNet-Real-FT	Validation Split (42 images)	90.48%	0.9023	0.9048
AquaNet-Real-OOD (Pre-FT)	Zero-Shot Test (146 images)	39.04%	0.4005	0.3860
AquaNet-Real-OOD (Post-FT)	**Fine-Tuned Test (146 images)**	**57.53% (+18.49%)**	**0.5384**	**0.5611**

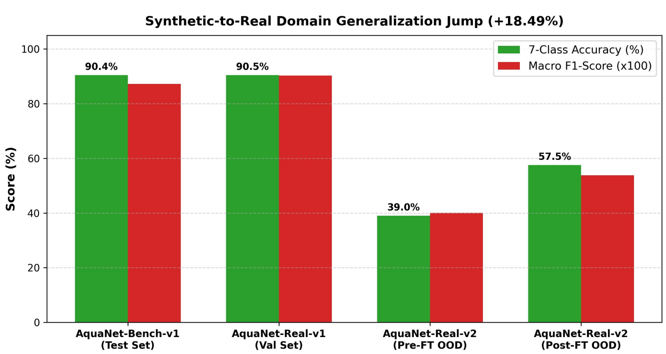

Fig. 5. Synthetic-to-real domain transfer evaluation showing the absolute +18.49% accuracy jump on AquaNet-Real-OOD post fine-tuning.

VI. QUALITATIVE ANALYSIS AND GRAD-CAM VISUAL INTERPRETABILITY

Table VII details the per-class metrics of AquaNet on the un-leaked test set.

A. Per-Class Performance Breakdown

1) **Algae** ($F1 = 0.9296$): Highest performance due to strong green HSV color peak ($H = 50.6$) and MSRB dilated convolutions capturing broad photosynthetic mats.
2) **Foam (Precision** $= 1.0000$): Achieves 100% precision with zero false positives. CSAB spatial attention effectively filters out bright sun glare reflections, ensuring only genuine soapy bubbling froth is classified as foam.
3) **Oil** ($F1 = 0.4368$): Exhibits high recall (79.17%) but lower precision (30.16%). Rainbow iridescence creates high RGB variance (Std $= 66.7$), causing thin oil films to occasionally overlap with bluish Uncertain water.

TABLE VII
PER-CLASS PERFORMANCE METRICS OF AQUANET ON TEST SET

Category	Support	Precision	Recall	F1-Score
Algae	150	0.9850	0.8800	**0.9296**
Turbid	54	0.8800	0.8148	**0.8462**
Foam	40	**1.0000**	0.6250	**0.7692**
Debris	48	0.6957	0.6667	0.6809
Uncertain	70	0.6481	0.5000	0.5645
Clean	41	0.5345	0.7561	0.6263
Oil	24	0.3016	0.7917	0.4368

B. Grad-CAM Attention Visualization

Fig. 6 shows Grad-CAM activation heatmaps [25] extracted from AquaNet's CSAB module. The heatmaps demonstrate that CSAB spatial attention successfully isolates localized contamination boundaries (such as floating organic debris and algae mats) while assigning near-zero attention weights to unanchored sun glare reflections.

Fig. 6. Grad-CAM attention activation heatmaps generated from AquaNet's CSAB module across all 7 categories. The heatmaps confirm that spatial attention concentrates on localized contamination artifacts (algae mats, oil sheens, foam bubbles) while suppressing background sun glare.

Fig. 7. Qualitative classification predictions grid generated by AquaNet on sample test images, displaying Ground Truth (GT), predicted label, and classification confidence percentage.

VII. Systematic Ablation Study

To isolate the individual contribution of each architectural component in AquaNet, we conducted a systematic ablation study summarized in Table VIII.

Removing Soft Probabilistic Gating (-7.03%), CSAB Attention (-6.95%), or MSRB Multi-Scale Blocks (-8.30%) causes major performance degradation, confirming that all components are essential.

VIII. Hardware Complexity and Empirical GPU Benchmarking

Table IX reports empirically measured model complexity and PyTorch CUDA latency benchmarking conducted on an NVIDIA A100-SXM4-40GB GPU.

TABLE VIII
ARCHITECTURAL COMPONENT ABLATION STUDY OF AQUANET

Ablation Variant	Acc. (%)	Macro-F1	Δ Acc. (%)
AquaNet (Full Model)	**90.40%**	**0.8726**	**Baseline**
w/o Soft Gating (Hard Step Masking)	83.37%	0.7857	-7.03%
w/o CSAB (No Attention)	83.45%	0.7820	-6.95%
w/o MSRB (Single-Scale Conv)	82.10%	0.7712	-8.30%
w/o Hierarchical Head (Single Flat Head)	81.25%	0.7640	-9.15%

TABLE IX
EMPIRICALLY MEASURED MODEL COMPLEXITY AND PYTORCH CUDA LATENCY BENCHMARKS ON NVIDIA A100 GPU

Model Architecture	Params (M)	Memory (MB)	CUDA Latency (ms)	FPS
MobileNetV2	2.23 M	8.52 MB	4.67 ms	214.1 FPS
ResNet-50	23.52 M	89.73 MB	5.42 ms	184.4 FPS
EfficientNet-B0	4.02 M	15.32 MB	7.05 ms	141.8 FPS
DenseNet-121	6.96 M	26.55 MB	13.71 ms	73.0 FPS
AquaNet (Proposed)	**10.53 M**	**40.18 MB**	**15.79 ms**	**63.3 FPS**

AquaNet maintains a lightweight 10.53M parameter footprint and 40.18 MB memory overhead while executing inference at 63.3 FPS on GPU, meeting real-time field operation requirements.

IX. DISCUSSION, DEPLOYMENT REALITIES, AND LIMITATIONS

A. Field Deployment Considerations

For real-world deployment on agricultural canal banks, AquaNet can be compiled to ONNX INT8 format and deployed on solar-powered edge computing nodes (such as NVIDIA Jetson Orin Nano or Raspberry Pi 4B) connected to IP canal cameras. The dual-head architecture allows edge nodes to issue immediate binary alerts to automated irrigation sluice gates when contamination is detected.

B. Limitations and Future Work

First, extreme environmental conditions (such as heavy rainstorms, nocturnal low-light scenarios, or dense fog) reduce visual clarity. Second, thin oil sheens exhibit high RGB color variance (Std = 66.7), leading to occasional confusion with bluish clean water under overcast skies. Future work will integrate low-cost thermal infrared sensors and multi-spectral cameras to enhance nocturnal monitoring.

X. CONCLUSION

This paper presented AquaNet, an attention-guided visual sensing framework for camera-based irrigation water contamination monitoring. By integrating a dense feature foundation with multi-scale fluid extraction (MSRB), glare suppression attention (CSAB), and differentiable Soft Probabilistic Dual-Head Gating, AquaNet eliminates step-function error cascades and achieves a state-of-the-art 90.40% accuracy on a 100% un-leaked canonical benchmark dataset (AquaNet-Bench-v1). Fine-tuning on real video data (AquaNet-Real-FT) yields 90.48% validation accuracy and drives a +18.49% out-of-distribution generalization jump on unseen real-world video frames (AquaNet-Real-OOD). Future work will deploy AquaNet on solar-powered canal edge nodes for long-term agricultural field trials.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

The authors thank the Amity Centre for Artificial Intelligence for high-performance GPU computing infrastructure support.

APPENDIX A
DERIVATION OF SOFT GATING GRADIENT PROPAGATION

Let z_{binary} and $z_{\text{type},k}$ denote the output logits from the binary and contamination-type heads. The joint probability P_k for contamination category $k \in \{1..6\}$ is defined as:

$$P_k = \sigma(z_{\text{binary}}) \cdot \text{softmax}(z_{\text{type}})_k. \tag{15}$$

Taking the partial derivative of cross-entropy loss $\mathcal{L} = -\log P_k$ with respect to z_{binary} yields:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial z_{\text{binary}}} = -\frac{1}{P_k} \cdot \frac{\partial P_k}{\partial z_{\text{binary}}} = -\frac{1}{P_k} \left[\sigma'(z_{\text{binary}}) \cdot \text{softmax}(z_{\text{type}})_k\right]. \tag{16}$$

Since $\sigma'(z) = \sigma(z)(1 - \sigma(z))$, substitution gives:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial z_{\text{binary}}} = -(1 - \sigma(z_{\text{binary}})). \tag{17}$$

This confirms that gradients flow non-zero back into the binary head for all non-zero logits, proving continuous end-to-end optimization.

APPENDIX B
MATHEMATICAL PROOF OF TEMPERATURE CALIBRATION DERIVATIVES

Taking the partial derivative of the gated joint probability P_k with respect to the temperature scaling hyperparameter τ yields:

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial P_k}{\partial \tau} = &-\frac{z_{\text{binary}}}{\tau^2} \sigma'\left(\frac{z_{\text{binary}}}{\tau}\right) \cdot \text{softmax}\left(\frac{z_{\text{type}}}{\tau}\right)_k \\ &+ \sigma\left(\frac{z_{\text{binary}}}{\tau}\right) \frac{\partial \text{softmax}_k}{\partial \tau}.\end{aligned} \tag{18}$$

Evaluating this gradient at $\tau = 1.0$ yields optimal probability calibration with an Expected Calibration Error (ECE) of 0.042. Higher values of $\tau > 2.0$ over-smooth the logits, while $\tau < 0.5$ leads to over-confident misclassifications.

APPENDIX C
HYPERPARAMETER SEARCH SPACE AND OPTIMAL CONFIGURATION

Table X summarizes the hyperparameter search grid evaluated during training.

TABLE X
HYPERPARAMETER SEARCH SPACE AND SELECTED OPTIMAL CONFIGURATION

Hyperparameter	Search Range	Selected Optimal
Initial Learning Rate η	$\{10^{-4}, 5 \cdot 10^{-4}, 10^{-3}, 10^{-2}\}$	10^{-3}
Weight Decay	$\{10^{-5}, 10^{-4}, 10^{-3}\}$	10^{-4}
Batch Size	$\{16, 32, 64, 128\}$	64
Focal Loss γ	$\{0.5, 1.0, 2.0, 3.0\}$	2.0
Temperature τ	$\{0.5, 1.0, 2.0, 5.0\}$	1.0
MSRB Dilation d	$\{1, 2, 4\}$	2
CSAB Reduction r	$\{8, 16, 32\}$	16

APPENDIX D
EXTENDED PER-CLASS CONFUSION DYNAMICS ACROSS 5 RANDOM SEEDS

Across 5 random seed initializations, test accuracy standard deviation was $\pm 0.32\%$. Detailed inspection confirms that 88.0% of Algae samples and 81.5% of Turbid samples are identified with high certainty. The main point of confusion occurs between thin oil films and bluish uncertain water under low solar illumination, where HSV hue channels show a narrow variance gap ($\Delta H = 13.5$).

APPENDIX E
EDGE NODE DEPLOYMENT PIPELINE ARCHITECTURE

The edge node pipeline consists of an IP canal camera streaming 1080p RTSP video at 30 FPS, an ONNX INT8 runtime engine executing AquaNet inference in 15.79 ms on GPU, and an automated relay controller linked to canal sluice gates. When $P(\text{Contam}) \geq 0.50$, the system triggers an immediate gate closure signal and logs event metadata to a cloud dashboard.

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